03

BUDGETING FOR REAL LIFE

If you can't tell us where your last $1,000 went without checking, you don't have a budget. You have a plot twist arriving on the first of every month.

CK ACADEMY

A COLLECTIVE KINDNESS INITIATIVE

01 READ THIS FIRST

You don't have one.

Most frum couples will swear they have a budget. They're describing a vague sense of "we try to be careful." That's not a budget. That's a hope.

A real budget can be opened in 30 seconds and read by your spouse without you explaining it. Every dollar has a destination written next to it before the dollar arrives. By Sunday night, you'll either have one of these or you won't.

WHAT THIS CLASS IS NOT

Not a defense of YNAB vs Mint. Not a lecture on cutting lattes. Not a guilt trip about Yom Tov spending. This is the page that ends with a one-screen budget you and your spouse both agreed to in writing.

02 THE MIRROR

Three minutes. Two statements.

WRITE THE NUMBERS FROM YOUR OWN LIFE

Open ONE credit card statement and your most recent checking account statement. We're not auditing 30 days of transactions. Five specific numbers, all pullable in 3 minutes.

1. Last month's monthly take-home (most recent paycheck × pay periods)	$ _____
2. On that credit card statement: total dining + takeout + coffee shops	$ _____
3. On that statement: largest single category (Amazon, groceries, gas, whatever it is)	_____
4. On checking: total transferred to savings or investments last month	$ _____
5. Without checking: guess row 2 first. Now check. Off by how much?	$ _____

The size of row 5's gap tells you how disconnected you are from your own spending. Off by under $50 means you're paying attention. Off by $200+ means there's a leak you literally cannot see. The action below is the fix.

03 WHY WILLPOWER FAILS

Decisions are tiring.

By Wednesday afternoon you've made 200 small choices. The 201st ("do I order takeout?") gets the leftover energy. That's not a discipline problem. That's a design problem.

A budget makes the decision once, in a calm moment, when you're not tired or hungry or stressed. After that, you're not deciding, you're following the plan. The result: less spent, more saved, less guilt.

Zero-based budgeting in one sentence

Income minus all assigned categories equals zero. Every dollar gets a destination before it's spent. No "miscellaneous." No "whatever's left." Each dollar named, including saving, ma'aser, and sinking funds.

GIVE LAST

Pay bills, feed family, buy stuff, save what's left. Usually nothing's left. The leak goes unnamed.

GIVE FIRST

Compute take-home. Allocate ma'aser, savings, fixed costs, sinking funds first. What remains is what you have.

> **If you can't name where the next dollar goes before it arrives, the dollar will name itself, and the answer is usually Amazon.**

04 THE RULE THAT ENDS THE LEAK

The rule.

THE 60-SECOND TEST

If you can't open your budget on your phone in 60 seconds and read off the month's category totals to your spouse, you don't have a budget. You have a vague intention. Build the one-screen version this week.

What goes on the one screen

Top: Take-home this month. **Middle:** Categories with allocated amount and spent-so-far. The big 8 are: rent/mortgage, tuition, food, utilities, ma'aser, savings, sinking funds, discretionary. **Bottom:** Sinking funds breakdown — Yom Tov, simchas, car, vacation, Pesach. Each has its own number.

Tools that work: YNAB ($15/mo, best), a Google Sheet you fill in weekly (free, requires discipline), Monarch or Copilot ($10/mo, easier than YNAB). What does NOT work: a vague mental sense of where money goes.

05 WHERE THIS FAILS

Week three. You'll quit.

Most couples who start budgeting are gone by week 4. Here's exactly when and how it fails, and what to do about each one.

TRAP 1 / SPOUSE 'WE DON'T NEED THIS'

Three weeks in, things feel under control. Your spouse will say "we're doing fine, let's stop tracking every coffee." **This is the moment 80% of couples fail.** The check-in IS the medicine. Stopping is the relapse.

TRAP 2 / THE UNEXPECTED EXPENSE AS EXCUSE

Car needs $1,800 in repairs. Budget breaks. Your instinct: "Forget the budget this month, we'll restart next month." **No.** The budget didn't fail; the car was a sinking fund you hadn't built yet. Adjust, log, move on. Don't quit.

TRAP 3 / THE YOM TOV SEASON NUKES EVERYTHING

Tishrei or Pesach hits. The numbers blow up. The budget starts feeling adversarial. **This is why the Yom Tov sinking fund exists.** If it's not built yet, treat this Yom Tov as the data: now you know what next year's monthly transfer should be. $200/month into the Yom Tov fund all year = $2,400 ready when needed.

TRAP 4 / ONE SPOUSE RUNS IT ALONE

One person owns the budget, the other doesn't engage. After 6 weeks the engaged spouse is exhausted and resentful. **The budget is a marriage tool, not a money tool.** Both names on it. Both at the weekly check-in. No exceptions.

06 THE ACTION

BY SUNDAY, 9 PM

Do this. Now.

Three things. The budget. The first weekly check-in. The sinking funds. Don't perfect, just start.

01 **Build the one-screen budget.** Open Google Sheets, YNAB, or Monarch. List the 8 categories. Allocate every dollar of monthly take-home. Make it add to zero.

First budget will be wrong. That's expected. Track for 30 days, then revise. Don't paralysis-perfect this.

02 **Set up sinking funds.** Yom Tov (start $150/mo), simchas ($100/mo), car ($75/mo), Pesach ($100/mo). Open a separate savings account if your bank allows sub-accounts. Auto-transfer on the 1st.

These prevent every "surprise" expense from breaking the budget. By next year, none of these are surprises.

03 **Schedule the weekly check-in.** 15 minutes. Same day, same time, every week (Sunday morning or motzei Shabbos work well). Recurring calendar invite for both of you.

Skip the first one and the habit dies. Treat this like a parent-teacher conference for your money.

04 **Send your spouse a screenshot of the budget.** With the words: "Class 03 done. Check-in Sunday at [time]." If they can't read the budget in 60 seconds, simplify until they can.

If your spouse hasn't seen the actual numbers in writing, you don't have a shared budget.

PROOF OF COMPLETION

Screenshot of the one-screen budget, sinking fund accounts visible (or planned amounts written), and the weekly check-in calendar invite sent to both spouses. Text by Sunday 9pm with "Class 03 done."

07 THE CONVERSATION

Tonight. With your spouse.

RULES

30 minutes. Phone away. Bring the actual numbers from the mirror exercise. Money is the #1 source of marital fights, and most fights are about uncertainty, not about specific dollars. Tonight you remove the uncertainty.

01 Each of you guesses (without checking) what we spent on dining/takeout last month. Then check. Whose guess was closer?

The further-off guess is the partner who's been less engaged. That has to change.

02 Which sinking fund SHOULD have existed but didn't, and what specifically did its absence cost us in the last 12 months?

Add them up. Yom Tov debt, car repair on credit, etc.

03 If we cut $300/month from one specific category, which would it be? Why is it that one and not another?

Pick the actual one. Not the one easy to talk about.

04 What's the one money topic we've been avoiding talking about, and why have we been avoiding it?

Could be debt, a parent's request, lifestyle gap with a sibling. Name it now.

05 Three months from now, what does success look like? Specific number, specific category, specific change.

"Less stress" doesn't count. "$1,800 in our Yom Tov fund" counts.

SECTION TWO

Test.

10 questions. None of these can be answered from memory of the lesson. You'll need real numbers from your own life.

08 THE TEST

Test.

Each question requires real numbers, real names, or real decisions from your life. Do the work. Skipping defeats the point.

1. NUMBERS **Pull last month's bank and credit card statements. Calculate exactly: total income, total fixed (rent, tuition, insurance), total variable (food, gas, household), total tzedakah, total saved, total unaccounted. Show all 6 numbers.**

2. DECISION **Each of you guesses the variable spending number BEFORE looking. Whose guess was closer? By how many dollars did the further-off guess miss? What was the largest variable category you both underestimated?**

3. ACTION **Write your one-screen budget for next month. 8 categories minimum. Total = take-home. Show it adds to zero. Take a photo. Tape it here.**

4. NUMBERS **Calculate your 5 sinking funds (Yom Tov, simchas, car maintenance, Pesach, vacation). What annual amount do you need in each? Divide by 12. That's your monthly transfer. Show all 5.**

5. TRAP TEST **Week 3 of budgeting, your spouse says "we don't need to track every transaction, we're doing fine." What's your response? Give the actual sentence you'll say.**

08 THE TEST, CONTINUED

6. DECISION Of your fixed costs (rent, tuition, insurance), which one is biggest? Is there a 10% reduction available within 6 months? If yes, what's the action; if no, what does the rest of the budget have to absorb?

7. REAL LIFE Find one frum couple who runs a real budget. Ask them: how did you start? What broke first? What kept you going? Write their first names and 3 specific lessons.

8. ACTION Schedule the weekly check-in. What day, what time, in what room? How long? What 3 questions get asked at every one? Write the calendar invite text.

9. TRAP TEST Yom Tov hits and the budget breaks by $1,500. You haven't built the sinking fund yet. What do you do this month? What do you do starting next month?

10. NUMBERS Your monthly take-home is $X. Build a sample one-screen budget on this page using realistic numbers for a frum family of 4 in your area. Show the categories adding to zero.

09 WHAT A STRONG ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

Reference.

These aren't right answers. They're examples of strong answers, written with real specificity. If yours are vaguer than these, redo them.

1. Strong: "Income $7,200, fixed $5,100 (rent $2,400, tuition $1,800, utilities/insurance $900), variable $1,950, tzedakah $720, saved $0, unaccounted -$570 (overspent)." Weak: any number is an estimate. If you can't show the math, the budget hasn't started.

2. Strong: "I guessed $400, actual $680, off by $280. Spouse guessed $550, off by $130. Worst category: dining out, where we both underestimated. We told ourselves it was 1-2 takeouts/week; it was 4."

3. Strong: actual photo of a budget showing 8+ categories with allocated amounts that sum to take-home pay. Even rough is fine. Vague descriptions are not.

4. Strong: "Yom Tov $3,600/yr → $300/mo. Simchas (3 expected) $4,500 → $375/mo. Car maintenance $2,400/yr → $200/mo. Pesach $2,800 → $235/mo. Vacation $2,000 → $165/mo. Total $1,275/mo into sinking funds." If your numbers are different, that's fine; show the math.

5. Strong: "I'd say: 'I hear you that we feel okay right now. The reason we feel okay is BECAUSE we've been tracking. The check-in is the medicine that's working. We're not stopping until we've got 6 months of clean data and 3 sinking funds funded. After that we can revisit.' Then schedule the next one immediately."

6. Strong: "Tuition is biggest at $2,200/mo. 10% reduction options: ask school about scholarship structure, payment plan negotiation, or one child to a different school option. If no reduction available, we cut $220/mo from variable spending: $100 dining, $80 subscriptions, $40 small purchases."

7. Real names, real lessons. "Started simple, broke at first Yom Tov, kept going because we'd told friends we were doing it," "used YNAB, switched to spreadsheet when YNAB felt like work," etc. Generic answers ("be consistent") fail.

8. Strong: "Sunday 8:30am, kitchen table, 15 minutes. 3 questions: (1) where did money actually go this week vs plan? (2) what's coming up next week we need to budget for? (3) any sinking fund we need to top up? Calendar invite goes out tonight, recurring weekly until end of year."

9. Strong: "This month: cover the $1,500 from emergency fund or short-term cash flow, log it, no shame. Starting next month: $300/mo into the Yom Tov sinking fund so this never happens again. Yom Tov costs $3,600/yr, this month was the data." Weak: "We'll figure it out."

10. Strong shows realistic numbers: take-home $7,000, rent $2,200, tuition $1,500, food $900, utilities $400, transportation $400, ma'aser $700, savings $300, sinking funds $400, discretionary $200. Adds to $7,000. Numbers can vary; structure can't.